from want of application of mind—as was argued by Siddaramaiah's counsel Abhishek Manu Singhvi—but was a case of 'abundance of application of mind', it noted.

The CM's legal advisor, A.S. Ponnanna, says Section 218 of the BNSS—which the court disregarded as premature—needs a prima facie offence to be made out whereas 17A of the PC Act is an approval where a suspicion or allegation existed. "It is only for an inquiry. At the inquiry stage itself, you are asking for resignation," Siddaramaiah said in response to calls for him to step down. Throughout the proceedings, the CM's arguments were that every act, right from 1992 till the grant of 14 compensatory sites to his wife, was done in accordance with the law and that she was not the sole applicant for grant of compensatory sites. There were 120 others whose lands were similarly taken over by MUDA.

However, citing a sale deed executed in favour of Parvathi in 2022 in the upscale residential locality of Vijayanagar 3rd stage in Mysuru, the HC noted that the Mysore Urban Development Authorities (Incentive Scheme for Voluntary Surrender of Land) Rules, 1991, indicated that a citizen who relinquishes property would be entitled to two sites measuring 4,800 sq. ft for relinquishing 3 acres.

"It shocks the conscience of the court as to how much is given to the petitioner...as against 4,800 sq. ft, it is 38,284 sq. ft The wife of the petitioner is now the owner of 14 sites worth Rs 56 crore...the benefit is by leaps and bounds," the judgment said. An inquiry is set to commence following the HC order, and with a combative Siddaramaiah digging in his heels, Karnataka's 16-month-old Congress government enters a turbulent phase. ■



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

GODDESS ROW
Durga idols being made at a workshop in Kumartuli, Kolkata

WEST BENGAL

THE PUJA DAMPENER

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

The famed 'puja spirit' that takes hold of Bengal each August, rising in a crescendo till the four-day Durga Puja festivities in October and lingering on till Diwali, has been muted this year. Social psychology, naturally, affects business. The state's puja economy is estimated to have touched Rs 50,000 crore last year, with retail business alone—apparel, footwear, home appliances, furnishing, gadgets, publishing et al—accounting for Rs 33,000 crore. The shopping frenzy these figures signify stands replaced by a wholly uncharacteristic tepidity, born of the sombre mood that has engulfed the state through the prolonged protests over the rape and murder of a trainee doctor at the RG Kar Medical College and Hospital on August 9. It was this backdrop that led to a wave of indignation when chief minister Mamata Banerjee asked protesters to "return to festivities" on September 9 at a televised meeting. The apathetic, pensive air is most apparent in Kolkata, the hub of spontaneous protests. Sales have been considerably down in each of the three big shopping areas of the city—Gariahat, New Market and Hatibagan—ahead of the October 9-12 Puja calendar. The prevailing mood of introspection that led to a social media and street campaign calling people to curb their festivities has affected the puja economy on which many livelihoods depend.

Rahul Saha, a 40-year-old apparel seller from Gariahat in south Kolkata, has not seen such a lukewarm pre-Durga Puja market since the two pandemic years. Shopkeepers here are usually run off their feet from mid-August, when the puja shopping crush begins in earnest. In the sultry